BUSINESS ACROSS THE AGES

Commerce, Wealth, and Ethics

in Comparative Religious Perspective

A Short Comparative Study

A Note to the Reader

Long before modern economics existed as a discipline, religious traditions were already legislating and moralizing about trade — what counts as a fair price, whether lending at interest is exploitation or ordinary finance, what a merchant owes the poor, and which goods should never be sold at all. This short book traces how six traditions have answered those questions across the centuries, and how each answer has shifted as economies themselves have changed, from village bartering to medieval guilds to global finance. As with the other books in this series, the aim is description, not judgment: each tradition contains internal disagreement, and the picture below is necessarily a compressed one.

Chapter 1: Why Religion Never Left Business Alone

Trade creates exactly the kind of situation religious ethics tends to worry about: two parties with unequal information, a chance for one to profit at the other's expense, and money changing hands in a way that can quietly reshape a community's fabric. It is not surprising, then, that nearly every major tradition developed specific teaching on honest weights and measures, fair pricing, lending, and the treatment of debtors — nor that those teachings have had to be renegotiated every time the underlying economy changed shape.

Chapter 2: Hinduism

Classical Hindu social theory assigned trade and commerce to the Vaishya varna as a specific dharmic occupation, treating honest business as a legitimate and even necessary path to two of the four traditional aims of life: artha (material prosperity) and dharma (righteous conduct), alongside kama (pleasure) and moksha (liberation). The Arthashastra, a detailed ancient treatise on statecraft and economics traditionally attributed to Kautilya, laid out extensive regulation of markets, weights, measures, and taxation, indicating that codified business ethics and commercial law in the Indian subcontinent go back well over two thousand years.

Wealth itself is not treated as suspect in Hindu tradition — Lakshmi, the goddess of prosperity, is one of the most widely worshipped deities — but wealth gained dishonestly, or hoarded without generosity, is consistently criticized. Charitable giving (dana) and hospitality remain closely tied to how legitimately earned wealth is expected to be used.

Chapter 3: Buddhism

Buddhism addresses business most directly through the concept of samyak-ajiva, or 'Right Livelihood,' one component of the Noble Eightfold Path. Right Livelihood requires that one's occupation not cause harm, and early texts specifically name several trades a lay Buddhist should avoid: trading in weapons, in living beings (including slavery), in meat, in intoxicants, and in poison.

Outside these specific prohibitions, Buddhism has generally been comfortable with commerce; historically, wealthy merchants were among the most important patrons of the early Buddhist sangha, funding monasteries and temples, and Buddhist teaching tends to focus less on regulating trade mechanics and more on the inner disposition of the trader — cautioning against greed (lobha) and attachment to wealth as sources of suffering, whatever one's occupation happens to be.

Chapter 4: Judaism

The Hebrew Bible contains detailed commercial law: commands for honest weights and measures (Leviticus 19:35–36), prohibitions on delaying a hired worker's wages (Deuteronomy 24:14–15), and a notable prohibition on charging interest (neshek) to a fellow Israelite, while permitting it in transactions with foreigners (Deuteronomy 23:19–20) — a distinction later rabbinic law worked through in considerable legal detail as Jewish communities operated within larger, non-Jewish economies across the diaspora.

Tzedakah — often translated as 'charity' but rooted in a word meaning justice or righteousness — frames giving to the poor as an obligation rather than pure generosity, and Jewish legal tradition developed graded categories of tzedakah, with anonymous giving and, above all, helping someone become self-sufficient (such as through a loan or job) ranked as the highest forms.

Chapter 5: Christianity

Medieval Christian canon law generally prohibited usury — lending money at interest — drawing on Old Testament texts and on Aristotelian arguments, developed at length by Thomas Aquinas, that money was 'barren' and should not generate more money simply by being lent. Alongside this, medieval theologians developed the doctrine of the 'just price,' the idea that a fair transaction should reflect a good's true value rather than whatever a desperate buyer could be made to pay.

This picture shifted substantially with the rise of merchant banking in late medieval Europe and, later, the Reformation. The sociologist Max Weber famously argued that certain strands of Protestant theology — particularly Calvinist ideas about work as a calling and worldly success as a possible sign of grace — helped legitimize capital accumulation and reshape European attitudes toward commerce, an argument that remains debated among historians but that captures a real shift: by the early modern period, most Christian traditions had moved from a blanket prohibition on interest to a more permissive stance focused on avoiding exploitative or excessive rates.

Chapter 6: Islam

Islamic teaching prohibits riba, usually translated as interest or usury, a prohibition stated directly in the Qur'an and elaborated extensively in Islamic jurisprudence. Because conventional interest-based lending is central to modern banking, this prohibition has driven the development of an entire alternative finance industry — Islamic finance — built on structures such as mudarabah (profit-sharing partnership), murabaha (cost-plus sale), and sukuk (asset-backed certificates functioning similarly to bonds without paying fixed interest), designed to allow investment and financing while avoiding riba.

The Prophet Muhammad himself worked as a merchant before his prophethood, and Hadith literature contains considerable praise for honest trade — one widely cited tradition places the truthful, trustworthy merchant among those who will be rewarded alongside prophets and martyrs. Zakat, the obligatory almsgiving that forms one of the Five Pillars, functions as a wealth tax of roughly 2.5 percent on qualifying savings and assets, giving Islamic economic ethics a built-in redistributive mechanism tied directly to religious obligation rather than voluntary charity alone.

Chapter 7: Sikhism

Sikh teaching organizes its economic ethic around three linked principles: Kirat Karo (earning an honest living through one's own effort), Vand Chakko (sharing what one has earned with others, especially those in need), and Naam Japo (remembering God). Together these principles explicitly reject both the idea that religious devotion excuses idleness and the idea that honest earning is an end in itself rather than something meant to be shared.

The institution of the langar — a free communal kitchen attached to every gurdwara, funded by voluntary donations and staffed by volunteer labor (seva) — puts Vand Chakko into direct daily practice, feeding anyone regardless of religion, caste, or economic status, and stands as one of the most visible institutionalized expressions of a redistributive economic ethic found in any of the traditions surveyed here.

Chapter 8: Side by Side

Tradition	View of Wealth	Interest / Usury	Redistribution Mechanism
Hinduism	Legitimate aim of life (artha) if honestly gained	Not categorically prohibited; regulated historically	Dana (charitable giving)
Buddhism	Acceptable if occupation avoids harm (Right Livelihood)	No blanket prohibition	Merchant patronage of sangha; personal generosity (dana)
Judaism	Positive; poverty not idealized	Prohibited among fellow Jews historically; permitted with others	Tzedakah (obligatory, graded giving)
Christianity	Debated across history; wealth as stewardship	Historically prohibited (usury); largely relaxed after Reformation era	Charity; varies widely by denomination
Islam	Positive if earned and shared honestly	Prohibited (riba); alternative finance structures developed	Zakat (obligatory ~2.5% wealth tax)
Sikhism	Positive if earned honestly (Kirat Karo)	Not a central doctrinal focus	Vand Chakko; the langar (free community kitchen)

Two patterns stand out across the ages. First, interest on loans has been the single most contested financial mechanism across these traditions — prohibited outright in classical Judaism and Islam, prohibited then substantially relaxed in Christianity, and never treated as a central doctrinal issue in Hinduism, Buddhism, or Sikhism. Second, every tradition surveyed pairs its view of legitimate wealth with an obligatory or strongly expected mechanism for redistributing some of it — tzedakah, zakat, dana, or the langar — suggesting a shared conviction, expressed through very different institutions, that private wealth carries a social debt attached to it.

Chapter 9: How the Ages Changed the Answers

None of these positions were fixed once and never revisited. Jewish and Christian usury law both had to adapt once banking became structurally necessary to their societies' economies — Christianity gradually relaxing an outright ban, Judaism refining a distinction between insiders and outsiders that became harder to sustain as Jewish communities integrated into broader economies. Islamic finance represents an ongoing, active project of the same kind happening in real time: reconciling a firm classical prohibition with the practical requirements of a modern, credit-based global economy through newly engineered financial instruments rather than by abandoning the underlying principle.

Hindu, Buddhist, and Sikh economic ethics have shown a different pattern of change — less a story of doctrinal reversal on a specific mechanism like interest, and more one of institutions (temple economies, monastic endowments, the langar, modern cooperative and microfinance movements associated with these regions) adapting older ethical commitments — honest earning, generosity, non-harm — to new economic structures as they arose.

Conclusion

Business has never been religiously neutral territory. Every tradition surveyed here treats how a person earns, prices, lends, and gives as a matter with real spiritual weight — and every one of them has had to keep answering that question freshly as trade itself evolved from marketplace bartering to medieval guilds to global digital finance. The specific rules have changed considerably across the ages; the underlying question — what does honest gain look like, and what do we owe once we have it — has not.